



Montagnard defenders

Soldiers from the hilltribes, or Montagnards, played a key role in opposing the NVA advance during the campaign in the Central Highlands. Here, Montagnard troops rest in camp at Kontum while B-52s bomb the surrounding area.

The action unfolds

Serious fighting began at the end of March with clashes in Binh Dinh province, where the NVA attempted to cut Route 19, which connected the coastal ports with the upland cities. In the Highlands, the NVA troops carried out bombardments on March 30, but held off on ground assaults for several more days. A serious engagement came near Dak To, where on April 1, ARVN troops faced NVA sappers. On April 3, Firebase Delta on Rocket Ridge was assaulted. By April 11, fighting had become generalized from Rocket Ridge to Dak To and Tan Canh. One by one the firebases fell in spite of B-52 air strikes.

Meanwhile, the South Vietnamese chose to move the airborne brigades out of the Highlands in exchange for the Sixth Ranger Group from Quang Tri. The Rangers were exhausted from nearly a month of fighting, and moving up troops of the 23rd Division at Pleiku simply weakened the defenses. Rocket Ridge positions collapsed, after which the NVA swiftly attacked the major base at Tan Canh, using tanks. Some tanks were destroyed from the air, but the ARVN at Tan Canh and Dak To collapsed on April 24.